

# The follower funnel

Week 1, Lecture 1 · Grow on X: From Zero to 10,000 Followers

Autumn 2026

## What we will cover

- The impression-to-follow funnel and its three conversion rates
- Why follower count is a lagging indicator
- The shadow audience: who they are and why they matter
- Setting a 90-day target and working backwards to daily actions

# Part 1: the funnel

## Three gates, three conversion rates

- Every follower passes through: impression, profile click, follow
- Each step has a conversion rate you can measure separately
- Most creators only see the end result (follower count)
- The funnel tells you *where* growth stalls, not just *that* it stalls

## The impression gate

- An impression = your post appears in someone's feed or search
- Driven by: relevance to the algorithm, reply activity, repost chains
- Impressions are not reach: the same person can generate multiple impressions
- Levers: posting time, topic fit, content format, reply to larger accounts

## The profile click gate

- Profile click = the impression was interesting enough to investigate
- Typical range: 1-5% of impressions become profile visits
- A single remarkable post can spike this rate dramatically
- Levers: clarity of the post's promise, curiosity gap, niche signal

## The follow gate

- Follow = the profile convinced the visitor this account is worth their feed
- This is entirely determined by your bio and recent post history
- A high profile-click rate with a low follow rate = bio problem, not content problem
- Levers: bio clarity, posting consistency, pinned post quality

## Part 2: lagging vs. leading



## Follower count is a lagging indicator

- It measures the result of decisions you made days or weeks ago
- You cannot change your follower count today
- You can only change the inputs that will move it tomorrow
- Watching it daily is watching the scoreboard, not playing the game

## Leading indicators to track instead

- Profile visits per post (measures profile-click conversion)
- Reply-to-impression ratio (measures how well content provokes conversation)
- Follows per post (measures bio-to-follow conversion)
- Percent of last 10 posts that drove at least one new follow

Track these weekly. Adjust. Repeat.

# Part 3: the shadow audience

## Who is the shadow audience?

- Lurkers who read every post but never engage publicly
- Repliers who share your content in private messages without tagging you
- Sharers who forward posts in group chats or Slack channels
- On most platforms, lurkers outnumber vocal followers roughly 9 to 1

## Why the shadow audience matters

- Public engagement (likes, replies) undercounts real reach
- A post with 40 likes may have been read by 4,000 people
- Signals the shadow audience is active: profile visit spikes, DMs from “long-time readers”
- Design content for lurkers: self-contained, clear, useful without prior context

# Part 4: the 90-day target

## Working backwards from a goal

- Target: 10,000 followers in 90 days = 13 weeks
- Start at 200 followers: need 9,800 new follows
- Weekly quota: 754 follows per week
- At 5 posts/week: 151 follows per post required

If your current rate is 30 follows/post, posting more does not close that gap.

## The gap is information

- A large gap between needed and current rate = a positioning or profile problem
- Fix the profile before increasing volume
- The 90-day frame lets compounding appear: weeks 10-13 are faster than weeks 1-3
- Kelly (2008): a small base of dedicated readers generates more growth than a large passive one



The average creator never stops focusing on the top of their funnel. To build a real business, you have to move people from the top down to the bottom.

<footer>Justin Welsh, "Metrics that Matter," 2023</footer>

## Take-aways

1. The follower funnel has three steps. Each has a separate conversion rate and a separate set of levers.
2. Follower count is lagging. The leading indicators worth tracking are profile visits, reply rate, and follows per post.
3. The shadow audience is real and larger than public engagement suggests. Write for lurkers.
4. A 90-day target converts ambition into a weekly quota. The gap between needed and current rate tells you what to fix.

## What's next

- **Reading:** Week 1 reading covers the full funnel plus niche and bio (read before section)
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** Niche, voice, and bio craft
- **Section (this week):** Audit five accounts in your niche using the funnel framework
- **HW 1 (out this week):** Niche statement and bio rewrite